The hierarchy of biological classification

The biological classification system has **seven ranks** or levels. The groups in the higher levels are larger and broader. They group living things that have just some things in common. The groups in the lower levels are smaller and more specific. They group living things that have many more things in common. The organisation of these groups is called the **hierarchy of classification**. Scientists sometimes disagree with the way others group organisms. For example, some scientists use only five kingdoms.

Level	
Kingdom	There are six kingdoms in the classification system: animal, plant, protista (single-celled organisms including amoebae), fungi, bacteria, archaebacteria (microorganisms also called extremophiles).
Phylum	There are more than 30 phyla in the Animal Kingdom and 10 in the Plant Kingdom. For example, Phylum Chordata includes humans, birds, fish and all other animals with a backbone.
Class	Each phylum is divided into classes. For example, Phylum Chordata includes the classes of amphibians, birds, mammals, reptiles and fish.
Order	An order is a subcategory of a class.
Family	Families are smaller groups within orders.
Genus	Species that share certain characteristics may be closely related, so they are grouped together in a genus.
Species	A species is a group of living things that can breed to produce fertile offspring.

☞ **1** Remember the seven levels of biological classification by saying 'King Phillip, Come Over For Good Soup!' Write the seven levels in order from highest to lowest.

1 _____ **5** _____

2 _____ **6** _____

3 _____ **7** _____

4 _____

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The hierarchy of biological classification CONT'D

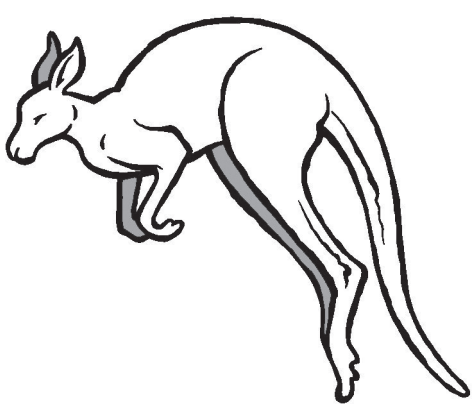
2 Write your own saying to help you remember the seven levels of biological classification. Hint: The first letter of the words in your saying should be, in order, K, P, C, O, F, G and S.

_____

_____

Every living thing can be classified into one group or category in each of the seven ranks. For example, a red kangaroo belongs to the following groups:

- Kingdom: Animal
- Phylum: Chordata
- Class: Mammal
- Order: Diprotodontia
- Family: Macropodidae
- Genus: *Macropus*
- Species: *Macropus rufus*



3 Use the information above to fill in the gaps and complete this passage. The first letter of each missing word has been given.

A red kangaroo is grouped in the Animal k_____ – along with birds, fish, humans, monkeys and many other animals – because it has all the characteristics of an a_____ (for example, it is a living organism that feeds on plants or other animals, it can move about and it has a nervous system).

It is also grouped in the Mammal c_____ – along with humans, monkeys and many other mammals – because it has all the characteristics of a m_____ (for example, it is warm-blooded, has fur and feeds its young with milk).

At its lowest or most specific level, the red kangaroo is classified as the s_____ *Macropus rufus*.

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